

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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Psalms

Psalms

Jesus and the apostles loved the book of Psalms. They quoted it often and shaped their lives by its teachings. These ancient prayers and songs of praise from Israel connect the Old Testament and the New Testament. Many themes that begin in the Psalms are developed further in the New Testament.

Where David's family line of kings not fully accomplish God's purposes, but Jesus brings hope and fulfills God's promises. At the same time, some expectations found in the Psalms still point to the future. God's people have not yet fully carried out all of his purposes, and not all nations have submitted to the Messiah (God's chosen King).

Summary

The psalms, like all Scripture, are inspired by God and given by him (see [2 Timothy 3:16](#)). At the same time, each psalm was written by a human author as a prayer or song of praise to the Lord.

The book of Psalms (also called the Psalter) contains many different kinds of writings. It includes laments (prayers of sorrow or complaint), songs of praise, wisdom teachings, prayers of thanksgiving, reflections on God's actions, celebrations of God's revelation (how God makes himself known), and songs used in worship.

The first two psalms introduce the entire Psalter. [Psalm 1](#) describes a righteous person who delights in God, follows his instruction, and does not follow the ways of evil people.

[Psalm 1](#) also raises three important questions:

1. Is there forgiveness for sins?
2. Why do righteous people suffer? and
3. Why do wicked people prosper?

The rest of the Psalter reflects on these questions and explores them in many different ways.

[Psalm 2](#) describes how the nations and the wicked rebel against God's rule. God judges those who oppose him and protects those who are faithful to him.

[Psalm 2](#) also raises two important questions:

1. Why do rebellious nations and wicked people prosper? and
2. Why were the kings from David's family line not victorious?

The psalmists (the people who wrote the psalms) spend much of the Psalter wrestling with these questions. Some accept their difficulties with quiet trust, while others question God or express deep frustration. As they continue their conversations with God, new questions and concerns also arise.

The Composition of the Psalms

Over a period of about one thousand years, poets wrote these songs, and people recited and collected them. Worship in the temple encouraged both the writing and the collection of psalms. Over time, editors combined smaller collections into larger ones. Eventually, they shaped five collections into the single book of Psalms.

This process of collecting and arranging the Psalter took place over many years and was completed after the exile to Babylon. Several features in the book point to this editorial activity:

1. The editors placed [Psalms 1](#) and [2](#) at the beginning of the book as an introduction to the entire Psalter. Both psalms present ideal examples. [Psalm 1](#) describes the ideal righteous person who lives by God's instruction. [Psalm 2](#) describes the Messiah (God's chosen King), the ideal king of Israel.

The rest of the Psalter develops these portraits in greater depth. At the same time, it explores how neither God's people nor their king were able to fully live according to God's purposes or bring about the joy and peace of God's kingdom.

1. Individual psalms were gathered into smaller collections. Editors then arranged these collections into five main sections:
 - Book One includes [Psalms 1–41](#) and ends with a doxology (a short song or statement of praise to God) in [41:13](#).
 - Book Two includes [Psalms 42–72](#) and ends with a doxology in [72:19](#).
 - Book Three includes [Psalms 73–89](#) and ends with a doxology in [89:52](#).
 - Book Four includes [Psalms 90–106](#) and ends with a doxology in [106:48](#).
 - Book Five includes [Psalms 107–150](#) and does not end with a doxology.
1. Books One ([Psalms 1–41](#)) and Two ([Psalms 42–72](#)) form the first major stage in the development of the Psalter. Book One is made up mostly of psalms by David ([Psalms 3–32](#); [34–41](#)). In Book Two, psalms by other authors appear alongside David's. These include:
 - the descendants of Korah ([Psalms 42–49](#)),

- Asaph ([Psalm 50](#)),
- David ([Psalms 51–65](#) and [68–70](#)),
- and Solomon ([Psalm 72](#)).

This shift shows a change in emphasis. David is no longer the only model and teacher. Other voices and perspectives are also included.

At the end of Book Two, the editor adds this comment: “Thus conclude the prayers of David son of Jesse” ([72:20](#)). This note remained in the book even after Books Three, Four, and Five were added, including additional psalms attributed to David.

1. Book Three ([Psalms 73–89](#)) shares several features with Book Two. Like Book Two, it often uses the name Elohim (a Hebrew name for God) in speaking about God ([Psalms 73–89](#); [Psalms 42–83](#)). It also includes psalms from different authors, including:

- Asaph ([Psalms 73–83](#)),
- those descended from Korah ([Psalms 84–85](#) and [87–88](#)), and
- David ([Psalm 86](#)).

[Psalm 73](#), which begins Book Three, raises questions about God’s justice and power. These questions challenge the hopeful picture of the Messiah’s kingdom presented in [Psalm 72](#), the final psalm of Book Two. Similar questions appear again in [Psalm 89](#), which closes Book Three.

1. The psalms in Book Four ([Psalms 90–106](#)) address questions that arose during the exile, when it seemed that God’s covenant with David had come to an end (see [Psalm 89](#)). In response to this crisis, several psalms encourage people to grow in character and faithfulness to God (see [Psalms 91–92](#)).

Many psalms in this section present God as the true and faithful King whose rule extends over all creation ([Psalms 93–100](#)).

God still loves his people, described as the flock of his pasture ([Psalm 100](#)). At the same time, they must listen to and obey him ([Psalms 95; 100](#)).

God forgives his people, and his compassion assures those in exile that he still cares for them. The review of Israel’s history (from creation to the Exile) in [Psalms 104–106](#) focuses on both God’s wisdom and Israel’s repeated failures. This history helps explain why the exile took place.

1. The blessing in [Psalm 106:48](#) also appears in [1 Chronicles 16:36](#). This might suggest that Book Four was completed after the exile, around the time when the book of Chronicles was compiled.
2. Book Five ([Psalms 107–150](#)) includes a number of smaller collections:

- the Egyptian Hallel ([Psalms 113–118](#));
- the Torah Psalm ([Psalm 119](#));
- the Great Hallel ([Psalms 120–136](#)), which includes the Songs of Ascents ([Psalms 120–134](#));
- eight psalms of David ([Psalms 138–145](#)); and
- five concluding hymns of praise ([Psalms 146–150](#)).

A major theme in Book Five is the movement from suffering and lament to God’s rescue and praise. This pattern begins in [Psalm 107](#). The final verse of that psalm ([107:43](#)) highlights the importance of wisdom in understanding God’s ways.

[Psalm 119](#), the longest psalm, celebrates God’s wisdom and his word. The psalms that recount the Lord’s care for Israel during their journey through the wilderness ([Psalms 114–118](#) and [135–136](#)) help God’s people understand David’s final prayers ([Psalms 138–145](#)) from a new perspective. These prayers look forward to God’s kingdom, especially in [Psalm 145](#). The psalms of praise ([Psalms 146–150](#)) affirm this hope.

1. Some psalms appear to have been expanded after they were first written. This may explain the prayer for the restoration of Zion in [51:18–19](#) and the prayer for God’s blessing on Jerusalem in [69:34–36](#). Changes in historical circumstances may have led editors to add new sections to these psalms.
2. The available manuscripts (ancient copies of the text) show that there was some variation in how the psalms were organized and titled. Both the Hebrew and Greek versions of the Psalter contain 150 psalms, but they differ in how some psalms are divided and numbered. They also differ in which psalms include titles.

In the Greek text, [Psalms 9](#) and [10](#) are combined into one psalm, and [Psalms 114](#) and [115](#) are also combined into one psalm. At the same time, [Psalms 116](#) and [147](#) are each divided into two psalms. Differences between the Hebrew and English numbering systems are noted throughout the study notes.

By the time of Jesus, the book of Psalms was already widely known and used (see [Luke 20:42](#); [Acts 1:20](#)). It was part of the third section of the Hebrew Scriptures, called the Writings (see [Luke 24:44](#)).

Author

Many of the psalms are associated with David, but not all of them. In fact, fewer than half of the psalms are explicitly connected to him. Other psalms are associated with:

- Asaph ([Psalms 50; 73–83](#)),
- the descendants of Korah ([Psalms 42–49; 84–85; 87](#)),

- Solomon ([Psalms 72; 127](#)),
- Heman ([Psalm 88](#)),
- Ethan ([Psalm 89](#)), and
- Moses ([Psalm 90](#)).

Of the 116 psalms that have titles, most name a person associated with the psalm. This person may have written the psalm, but that is not always certain. The Hebrew preposition *le* before a name (often translated “of”) can also mean “for,” “dedicated to,” “concerning,” “to,” or “by.” For example, *ledawid* (often translated “of David”) could also be understood as “for David,” “dedicated to David,” “concerning David,” or “by David.”

Many of the psalms “of David” may have been written by David, but there are several reasons to be cautious about this conclusion. Some titles include two names, such as David and Jeduthun or Asaph ([Psalms 39, 62, 77](#)). In these cases, the other person may have been the author of the psalm.

In addition, several psalms are linked in their titles to events in David’s life ([Psalms 3, 7, 18, 34, 51, 52, 54, 56, 57, 59, 60, 63, 142](#)). However, the content of these psalms often contains few details that clearly connect them to those events. For example, the title of [Psalm 51](#) links the psalm to David’s sin and Nathan’s rebuke. The psalm speaks about sin, forgiveness, and repentance (turning away from sin), but it does not mention many details of that specific situation.

Some psalms “of David” also seem to assume that the temple already existed, even though it was not built until after David’s death (see [Psalm 5:7; 122:title; 138:2](#)). Likewise, the title of [Psalm 30](#) connects David with the dedication of the temple, and [Psalm 69](#) does not appear to fit well with what is known about David’s life.

Finally, some ancient textual traditions differ in whether David’s name appears in certain titles (for example, [Psalms 122, 124](#)). Because of these factors, *ledawid* may often mean “for David,” “dedicated to David,” or “concerning David” rather than “by David.” In such cases, the psalm may present David as the leading representative of his royal family line without implying that he personally wrote it.

Even so, many psalms may have been written by David.

Literary Issues

The title *Psalms* comes from the Greek word *psalmos*, which means “song” (see [Luke 20:42; 24:44](#)). This word translates the Hebrew word *mizmor*, which appears in

the titles of many individual psalms (for example, see [Psalm 3:title](#), where it is translated “psalm”).

The word *mizmor* is related to a Hebrew verb that means “to play a stringed instrument.” This suggests that the psalms were originally sung with musical accompaniment. Before they were collected into a book, they were also part of Israel’s oral tradition (material passed on by speaking and singing rather than by writing).

The Hebrew title of the book of *Psalms* is *tehillim*, which means “praises.” This word is related to *hallelujah*, which means “praise Yahweh” (the personal name of God in the Old Testament).

Psalm Titles

The psalm titles, also called superscriptions (short notes that appear before a psalm), provide information about many of the psalms. These titles may identify a person associated with the psalm, describe the type of psalm (such as a song or prayer), give musical instructions, explain how the psalm was used, provide historical background, or indicate a dedication.

However, the meaning of much of this information is uncertain. For this reason, many scholars do not place strong emphasis on the psalm titles when interpreting the psalms.

In Hebrew editions of the psalms, the title is usually counted as verse 1. Because of this, the verse numbers in many psalms differ by one verse from those found in most English translations.

Interlude (Selah)

The Hebrew word *Selah* appears throughout the book of *Psalms*. Its exact meaning is uncertain, but it is probably a musical or literary term. In the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), it is always transliterated as *Selah*. Some translation, like the New Living Translation (NLT), translate it as “Interlude.”

Groupings of the Psalms

The psalms can be grouped in a number of ways:

- **By the names used for God.** Some collections mainly use *Yahweh* (translated “the LORD” ; [Psalms 1–41](#)), while others mainly use *Elohim* (a Hebrew name for God; [Psalms 42–72](#)).
- **By the names in the titles.** Some psalms are associated with David ([Psalms 3–32; 34:1–41:13](#), and others). Others are associated with the descendants of *Korah* ([Psalms 42–49; 84:1–85:13; 87:1–88:18](#)). Others are associated with *Asaph* ([Psalms 50, 73–83](#)).

- **By genre (type of psalm).** Examples include psalms of praise, lament, thanksgiving, and wisdom (discussed in more detail in the next section).
- **By existing collections within the Psalter.** One example is the Songs of Ascents ([Psalms 120–134](#)). Jewish tradition also recognized other collections, such as the Egyptian Hallel ([Psalms 113–118](#)) and the hallelujah hymns ([Psalms 146–150](#)).
- **By shared themes.** Examples include God's kingship ([Psalms 93–100](#)) and the storyline from creation to the exile ([Psalms 104–106](#)).

Genres of the Psalms

The titles of many psalms identify the type, or genre, of the psalm. The most common genre term is the Hebrew word *mizmor*, which refers to a song that was originally accompanied by stringed instruments.

Other genre terms appear less often:

- *maskil* (a type of psalm or chant; [Psalms 32; 42; 44–45; 52–55; 74; 88–89](#)),
- *miktam* (a type of psalm or chant; [Psalms 16; 56–60](#)),
- *shir* (“song”; [Psalms 45; 120–135](#)),
- *shiggayon* (a type of psalm; the exact meaning is uncertain; [Psalm 7](#)),
- *tepillah* (“prayer”; [Psalms 17; 86; 90](#)),
- *tehillah* (“psalm of praise”; [Psalm 145](#)),
- *higgayon* (“meditation”; the exact meaning is uncertain; [Psalm 9:16](#)), and
- *todah* (“psalm of thanksgiving”; [Psalm 100](#)).

The precise meaning of some of these Hebrew terms is not known. They may describe a type of psalm, a musical style, or how the psalm was used in worship.

In addition to the genre labels found in the Hebrew text, the psalms can be grouped into three main categories:

1. **Wisdom or instructional psalms**, which teach people how to live according to God's ways ([Psalms 1, 15, 24, 33, 34, 37, 73, 90, 107](#)).
2. **Psalms of lament**, which express sorrow, suffering, questions, or requests for help. These can be divided into individual laments and community laments. Most of the psalms in Books One through Three belong to this category.
3. **Psalms of praise or thanksgiving**, which celebrate God's character and actions ([Psalms 8, 19, 29, 65, 67, 114](#)). These can also be divided into individual and community psalms.

The psalms of praise include several smaller categories:

- **Royal psalms**, which focus on the king ([Psalms 2, 45, 72, 89, 110](#));

- **Psalms about the Lord's kingship**, which celebrate God as king ([Psalms 93, 95–99](#));
- **Creation hymns**, which praise God as the Creator ([Psalms 19, 29, 104](#)); and
- **Zion hymns**, which focus on Zion (Jerusalem, the city associated with God's presence and rule; see [Psalms 46, 48, 84, 87](#)).

Another way to read the Psalms is to focus on a pattern that appears in many of them. Many psalms move from instruction to a problem, and then from the problem to renewed commitment and changed character.

The Psalter is also instructional in its overall purpose. As a collection of five books, it is intended to teach God's people how to live. [Psalm 1:2](#) describes it as *torah* (instruction), highlighting its role in guiding God's people in God's ways.

The Psalms in Israel's Worship

The book of Psalms contains important information about music in ancient Israel. Most of the psalms are songs of praise, thanksgiving, prayer, or repentance.

Some psalms were used on specific occasions. For example, [Psalms 113–118](#) were associated with the Passover festival, and [Psalms 120–134](#) were used by people traveling to Jerusalem for the annual festivals.

The psalms also include songs that recount important events in Israel's history. For example, [Psalm 30](#) is described as “a song for the dedication of the temple,” and [Psalm 137](#), reflects the suffering of God's people during the Babylonian exile.

These psalms played an important role in the life of the community, although the exact nature of that role is not fully known.

Meaning and Message

The psalms give us insight into the hearts and lives of the faithful people who wrote them. Their reflections on God are honest and thoughtful, not simple or superficial. As their faith is tested, it becomes stronger and more refined.

The psalms model deep character, wisdom, honesty, and sincerity. But the prayers in the Psalter are more than examples to follow. They are part of God's *torah* (instruction; see [Psalms 1; 19; 119](#)) and teach God's people how to live rightly.

Through the psalms, God teaches his people who he is, what he has done, and what he expects from them. The psalms focus on God. They help his people recognize their own failures, receive his correction, and become

more like him. They also encourage God's people to worship him wholeheartedly and to tell others about him.

The writers of the Psalms reflected on how short and uncertain life can be. They wrote about suffering and the many hardships that people experience. In times of pain, loneliness, and rejection, they longed for God's presence, care, and protection (for example, [Psalm 23](#)). They also looked forward to the lasting glory that God would provide.

Even the psalms associated with David often present him as humble rather than triumphant. They show him experiencing humiliation, weakness, and suffering rather than glory. Like David, the writers of the Psalms experienced shame and rejection, and they longed for redemption (God's rescue and restoration). They trusted that the Lord would ultimately vindicate them and show that they were in the right.

The Psalter shows the failures of both Israel and David's royal family line. Even the most faithful people in Israel and the best of its kings were unable to bring about the joy and peace described in [Psalms 1](#) and [2](#) (see also [Psalm 72](#)).

The psalms therefore encourage each person to seek wisdom, trust in God, and live by his grace. They also point God's people toward the one who can bring blessing to a world in need and give them hope in him.

The psalms prepare God's people for the coming of Jesus Christ, the perfect human being and the ideal king. He is the descendant of David who lived with complete faithfulness and integrity. Jesus and the apostles understood his life and ministry in light of the psalms (see [Matthew 13:34–35; 21:16, 42; 23:39; John 2:17; 15:25; 19:24, 28, 36; Acts 2:22–35; 4:11; 13:32–38; Romans 15:3; 1 Corinthians 15:25–27; Ephesians 4:7–10; 1 Peter 2:7](#)).

Jesus entered the human world and experienced the patterns found in the Psalms, including humiliation, suffering, death, vindication (God's public approval), and glory. He is the only person who has completely pleased God ([Psalm 1](#)). He is the Messiah (God's chosen king) and the king described in [Psalm 2](#). Through Jesus, God brings redemption, joy, and peace to his people.